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Joe Wilder

Joe Wilder was born in Pennsylvania on February 22, 1922, and he was raised in Philadelphia. His classmates at the Mastbaum School of Music were Buddy DeFranco and Red Rodney. His trumpet playing has been heard with Les Hite, Lionel Hampton, Jimmy Lunceford and Count Basie, as well as in the pit orchestras of New York and he has been called on to perform in the New York Philharmonic and the Smithsonian Jazz Repertory Orchestra. He is a highly respected musician for his skill in ensembles and for his personal jazz phrasing. His most recent album is entitled "No Greater Love."

Joe was interviewed by Monk Rowe at the Sarasota Jazz Festival on April 12, 1996.

MR: We are filming today for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive. My name is Monk Rowe, and I'm very pleased to have Joe Wilder with us. Thank you very much for coming.

JW: Oh, thank you for inviting me, Monk. I'm sorry you had to track me down.

MR: Well you had such a busy schedule here I feel like I should talk real fast.

JW: Not from my own doing, unfortunately.

MR: Yes. In fact, it seems like your life is busier than ever.

JW: It seems to be and I'd rather that it weren't actually. But it's okay, I can't complain.

MR: What are some of the things you've been doing? I know we have one of your recent records here and —

JW: Well that's the most recent one, and there is also one I did with Dick Hyman, the name of which I don't remember, but it's a recent one also. But this is the last one I have.

MR: In the past few years you've played with the Smithsonian —

JW: Yeah I played with the Smithsonian Jazz Masterworks Orchestra, and that's under the direction of Gunther Schuller and Dave Baker.

MR: Yeah? How often is that group together?

JW: Well usually we would be starting some of the activities about this time of year. For some reason or other, I think it may have something to do with the funding I'm not sure, but that might be what's holding it up at the moment.

MR: And also with the Lincoln Center? Or is it Carnegie?

JW: No I played with that orchestra only on one occasion, what is it '92 I guess. One of the trumpet players became ill and they needed someone at the last minute and called me to go in for him. And I did six weeks of one-nighters. And when I went out I guess I was seventy-some years old, or seventy years old and I came back I was about ninety. I haven't been on the road like that for years.

MR: That can be a tough thing, can't it?

JW: Eh, it was nice. It was interesting because, and I sat next to Wynton, who is musically a joy you know, and I had a lot of fun, I had a lot of fun.

MR: The little I've got to know you on the phone, it sounds to me like you're a person who really puts a lot of stock in a good work ethic. Is that, I mean, being on time and all that kind of — it's very important. It's not that way for all musicians, or in any line of work I guess.

JW: Yeah, that's true.

MR: It's a pleasure to see that. Did you come from a musical family?

JW: My father played, originally cornet and then he switched to sousaphone and while he was playing sousaphone he studied bass violin and so he doubled on sousaphone and bass violin when that was in vogue, and then later on he just played bass violin. And my father played I guess until he was about 87, or no I guess he was 88. And he sent me a letter saying he had played the bass violin as long as he wanted to and he felt that that was enough and he stopped.

MR: At 88.

JW: And he stopped playing. I think he stopped for about two years and then he went out and got a Fender bass and started practicing that. But now he doesn't play at all. He sold his acoustic bass.

MR: That's interesting.

JW: Yeah, he was 95 on Thanksgiving Day.

MR: Great. And were you classically trained as a musician? You had classical training?

JW: Me?

MR: Yeah.

JW: Oh, yeah. I had a lot of classical training. I went to the Mastbaum School in Philadelphia with Buddy DeFranco and Red Rodney, and a bunch of guys. And John LaPorta.

MR: Oh yeah. What were the opportunities like back at that time for a musician such as yourself?

JW: Well the opportunities for black musicians in the concert field were nil, I mean they just weren't there. And you sort of, I was still interested in classical music and because of that I guess I studied pretty hard at what I was doing at the time and I guess it gave me a little more momentum when I became a commercial player, it was a big help to me, discipline-wise and things like that. But I must say because of having more interest at that point in classical music when I was younger, it inhibited my jazz playing a great deal because I just didn't feel comfortable and I didn't play very well actually. I was very stiff. Now, in later years of course I've been doing more of that and I feel more relaxed with it and probably play a little better at it.

MR: You sound like you play a lot better at it today. And you've played with the New York Philharmonic?

JW: I subbed with them a few times with Boulez was there and when Kostelanetz was there. And usually there was times when they were doing "The Pines of Rome" and they added a couple of extra trumpets or something.

MR: How about your first big band experience? You've played in so many big bands.

JW: The first big band I played with, a name orchestra, was Les Hite. I played in that band and during the time I was in that band Dizzy Gillespie also joined it, Britt Woodman was the first trombone player, and Gerald Wiggins, Britt Woodman and his brother Coney, who was our pianist, were drafted at the same time. And Gerald Wiggins joined the band. He was in the band at the time Dizzy Gillespie was in the band for a short time.

MR: Did you get to do some traveling at that point, around the country, did you travel?

JW: Yes, we traveled quite a bit, right. And from that band, I finally went, I joined Lionel Hampton's band from Les Hite's band. And I was in Lionel Hampton's band in 1943 at the time I went into the service.

MR: Can you give — we have a student sitting watching this tape — can you give him an idea of what it was like to be in a large group, and crisscrossing the country at that time?

JW: Well it was interesting to me because having just come out of school I had a lot of interest in geography, which now I began to see laid out before me. That made it interesting. And you know seeing people, meeting people in different states and finding out that most of us think the same way and that we have the same ideas about what the country is and what the world is to a great extent. And this of course kind of reinforced your own thoughts. I found that interesting. And the reaction of people to what you were playing was nice too, that was very encouraging.

MR: Mostly dances?

JW: Almost all dances, yeah.

MR: Would you have a certain group of people in front of the stage perhaps that just wanted to watch?

JW: We had that. People who came, the aficionados who just came to listen and decide whom they liked best in the band and things of that type, and others were out there dancing the whole time you know. But there was always interest in listening to what we were playing, for all the bands.

MR: It's so fascinating to think that at that time the music you were playing is like the rock 'n roll of today. It was the popular music.

JW: At that time it was, yes it was, it was quite popular. And another thing, people listened to a lot of your recordings so that when you went to a town to play, if you had a few recordings out they had listened to them and they knew every note, certainly of the

ensemble playing you know, and some of the solos, if you repeated them the same way each time, they could hum them note for — or sing them note for note you know. That was true with Benny Goodman and all the big bands at that time.

MR: And Hamp was quite a showman, wasn't he, at that time?

JW: Oh yeah. Hamp's band was some band. It was an exciting band to play in, it was a very innovative band, and it was a new style, it was a completely different sound they had. A very exciting band, a bunch of young fellas in there, Ernie Royal, Joe Newman and guys like that, Illinois Jacquet, Dexter Gordon, they were all in that band. Irving Ashby, who later was with Nat King Cole, the guitarist. And speaking of, we had a saxophone player, Ray Perry, who played third alto, who played violin like Fiddler Williams you know? I mean but really, like a saxophone player. He played with that kind of phrasing you know, with an amplified violin. He was great too. It was an interesting band.

MR: Did you have an opportunity to go overseas a lot?

JW: Not during that time. I never went overseas until 1954 and I went with Count Basie. That was the first time.

MR: How did the gig with Basie come about? It's usually word of mouth, isn't it, that leads somewhere?

JW: Well I knew Basie and I knew a lot of people in the band. But Joe Newman was the featured trumpet soloist basically. He played most of the trumpet solos, not all of them, but he was working so much and he said that they needed to get someone else to take some of the load off of him. And Basie was looking for someone and that's how I came to join the band. And it was actually, to take a little of the pressure off Joe.

MR: Did you get a lot of his solos?

JW: Excuse me?

MR: Did you get a lot of his solos?

JW: I did some, yes, I had some too. Yeah. It was interesting you know, it was interesting. I was telling that story this morning, about after having joined the band I was there a couple of weeks, a few weeks, and I hadn't played any solos. And I was getting a little frustrated. So I wrote a little note to Count Basie and I said "Bas, could I play a couple of choruses of just about anything?" And I signed it "the trumpet player second from the drums." You know Joe sat here, I sat here and the drums are there. And I passed the note over to Basie, and Basie took it, and he stopped playing and he looked at it and he said "you want to play, go ahead and play." And you know he was very nice you know.

MR: Yeah. The new guy in the band, you know, oh my. What's the — I read something, I think it may have been with Hampton, about the Barracuda?

JW: Oh, geez. Barracuda was a mythical person who came to clean up everything that was unsavory or whatever. Lionel Hampton for instance, his wife would buy a hat for him, a

Stetson hat or some expensive hat, and when they put it on him in the shop it looked just great. And when he'd come out he'd have it on. Then the first time he took it off and put it on again, instead of the brim being like this it would be way, and of course he had it turned at an angle, and the guys would say, "you know that hat looks pretty bad" and someone would say, "yeah probably before the night is over Barracuda will have it." And before the night would be over, Lionel would go to sleep on the bus or on the train, and the hat would disappear, gone out the door of the train or someplace, they'd throw it away. Or if they had some arrangements, we'd get some arrangements, and nobody particularly liked it, and the guys would say, "well I think before this week is out our Barracuda will probably end up with the first trumpet part, and the first alto part or something," and sure enough, Lionel would call that tune a couple of nights later and guys would start fishing and say, "geez, I can't find the first trumpet part," and, "the lead alto part is gone." And "the trombone parts are gone." And it would be gone. They'd throw it away. With Dinah Washington, she joined the orchestra, and we were on a train making a long trip and she had these bedroom slippers on, like rabbit fur, and the guys would say, "you know this really brings the band down," you know, the guys were saying, "don't worry, Barracuda will take care of it." And of course she woke up the next morning and she had one slipper. They would do things like that.

MR: But to throw away the one is even better too. You know, if they're both missing — but one is perfect.

JW: That's who "Barracuda" was. We never discovered exactly who he was but he was there.

MR: Oh, boy. Have you lived in New York most of your life?

JW: I guess yes I have as a matter of fact, since 1947. I was born in Colwyn, Pennsylvania though. And I went into the Marine Corps for three years and when I came out I went back with Lionel Hampton and I stayed there a short time and I wasn't very happy and I left that band and went with Jimmy Lunceford.

MR: Were you able to play in the service?

JW: Yeah, I was the Assistant Bandmaster at Montford Point Marine Base. My platoon, as a matter of fact, this was one of the first times they had black Marines. And my platoon brought the number of black Marines to ten hundred, the first ten hundred black Marines.

MR: Most of the musicians we've talked to who were in the service, were able to play music.

JW: Most of them were, yeah. But we took regular Basic Training too, so that we were always being reminded that you are in the band but you're in the Marine Corps too you know.

MR: Well New York was a pretty hot town, 52nd Street and all of that?

JW: All those places. But oddly enough, and I almost hate to admit it, I never went there. I don't drink and I don't smoke, and I couldn't stand the smoke in most of the clubs you know. And I played in Birdland with Count Basie and I played in another place called

Bop City with Herbie Fields' band. And I always had difficulty with the smoke in those places. So I tried to stay away as much as possible, and I never went into the clubs on 52nd Street. And it's almost criminal that I was here when they were running, that I was there rather when they were functioning, but I just never went. I admired the guys who were working there, they were tremendous.

MR: The jam session was a big part of learning music.

JW: Oh, yeah. I used to go to Minton's, guys used to jam in there sometimes and play with Charlie Parker and Monk used to play there, and what's her name, Carmen McRae, she used to sing there and she used to play piano sometimes. She played piano very well. And sometimes she would be there and I'd play behind here on something you know.

MR: It seems like I read something about a fellow that you called "The Demon?" "The Demon?"

JW: Oh, The Demon, at Minton's.

MR: Now who was this?

JW: He was a tenor player, I think he played tenor. And he was a fellow who didn't play very well. But he was very persistent. He would come up and when all the other guys were up there jamming, guys who were known to be pretty talented, and he would just stand there and sort of look, with his horn hanging, and say, like you know, "when do I play?' you know or something. And finally somebody'd say, "okay, come on in." They called him "The Demon" because he would play like ten choruses and compiled they wouldn't make one decent chorus, but he would never let up. So he'd play maybe eight or nine choruses or something, and the guys would be saying will he ever stop you know. And then Teddy Hill, the former band leader, was the manager of the club. And Eddie "Lockjaw" Davis was like the major domo in this place. And the guys would say, he'd be standing up there, and he's the one, he'd be very nice and he'd say, "okay, come on Demon, you can play." And he'd get fed up and he'd say like, "okay, you gonna stop?" The guy would keep playing. He would go get Teddy Hill and he'd say, "Teddy, come get The Demon." And Teddy would come and Teddy would stand there, and the Demon would still be playing, and Teddy would turn and say, "okay Demon, get off my bandstand." It was crude but it was comical too you know. And he never stopped. The next night he'd be back doing the same thing. Yeah. There were some funny times.

MR: The Basie band, you were with them what, just about a year?

JW: No, I was with them far less than a year.

MR: Yeah?

JW: Yeah. It was a very short time.

MR: Was Joe Williams on the band at that time?

JW: No, Joe wasn't on the band at that time. I met Joe Williams, incidentally the first time I worked with Joe Williams, he was the vocalist with Lionel Hampton's band. He sang in Lionel Hampton's band. No blues, he was a ballad singer, and a good one. He sang ballads, beautiful singer. And when he started with the blues in Basie's band, I was surprised you know, because I knew him as a ballad singer and a really good ballad singer. He still does for that matter.

MR: All of a sudden he's like the blues man.

JW: Yeah. He is the blues singer of today.

MR: That's great. Benny Goodman? You traveled with Goodman some?

JW: Yeah. I went to Russia with Benny for the State Department. That was an interesting trip. It was a good orchestra, a really good orchestra. And had Benny been nicer on the trip I think we would have all had a wonderful time. But the guys in the band were so fond of each other that it just took the curse off anything else that was unpleasant you know. That was an interesting trip, very interesting. You could, the Cold War was at its peak, and you could just feel the tension, especially in Moscow and Leningrad, where you had a lot of military people, and it was just like a very eerie kind of a feeling, like at any moment you sort of felt that a war could break out. There was just a pall over everything there you know. And people were suspicious, they watched you, they just seemed to feel that anything, if you took a picture you were going to take a picture that would denigrate the people, and it was a little difficult. I don't think any of us actually became close friends with anybody there because you couldn't get that close to the people. They were afraid, and we had been warned to be careful you know.

MR: Wow. To be so far from home.

JW: And yet the people were just like people here, if you had removed them bodily from where they were and put them here, you would never have known that they were from Russia and I'm sure if we had done the same with us, they wouldn't have seen the difference either you know. But it's a psychological thing. It's actually dangerous.

MR: What are some of your favorite things you've done in the last couple of years?

JW: The things I've done in the last few years? Well I did, well I was lucky enough to play a Broadway musical that ran eight and a half years. I did a lot of Broadway shows but the last one I did was "42nd Street" the David Merrick show, and that ran for eight and a half years. So that was a long run. It's not a long run by "A Chorus Line" standards or "Cats," those shows are still going, and "Les Mis'" they're really setting records. But they're good shows you know.

MR: Can I guess that you had the music memorized by the time the eight and a half years was up?

JW: Yes you can to a great extent but you have to also be careful that you continually flip the music over even though you've committed most of it to memory, because if you have a breakdown on the stage, and you need to start at a certain point, you've got to have that reference point there you know.

MR: Yeah. Did you do much studio work over the years?

JW: Oh, yeah. That's what I used to do mainly. I worked for the American Broadcasting Company for seventeen years. And then during that period I also did a lot of work for CBS and NBC and we did a lot of recording work. I mean in fact, what I did most in my early years in New York was jingles and commercials. We used to do all the cigarette commercials, Kent and Lucky Strike and all those things, I mean they were actually a mainstay for many of us for a long time, and I don't smoke at all, so when they stopped advertising them we lost a lot of business in that.

MR: Your classical training must have helped in the studio work.

JW: Oh, yeah, it did. Because we had a lot of transpositions to make, you know a lot of that. It was important and it was a big help. And we used to do, at ABC, they had the staff orchestras at all the networks, and you did whatever work there was to be done, whether it was classical or jazz or commercial, you know you just did whatever there was to be done. And most all the guys were that versatile for that matter.

MR: And they didn't like to spend time getting it right. I mean I would imagine like do it right the first time.

JW: Right. Well it just got to the point where you were so accustomed to sight reading things as a regular thing in your daily routine, that you almost looked forward to it. It became like a challenge. Let's see if we can play this the first time as if we've been playing it a hundred times. And some, for the most part, all those staff orchestras would sit down and they'd take a piece of music and they would play it as well the first time as they did the tenth time. It just got to be natural.

MR: Wow. Well this has just been really fascinating.

JW: Well thank you.

MR: I'm looking forward to — you have more recording plans I hope?

JW: I don't know, I don't know. It depends. I've had some dental work done and I'm having, I'm not too happy with the results I'm getting with my playing as a result of it, and I have to have some adjustments made and when I go back to New York I'll see what I can do about it and see if it improves. If it doesn't, then I'll know it's the end of the line and try to accept it gracefully.

MR: One tune on here was so — "Love Me Tender." Gee. What made you pick —

JW: I really don't know. You know I'll tell you, while there was this whole thing going on at that time about it was getting close to some anniversary, an Elvis Presley anniversary or

something, and while I wasn't an Elvis Presley fan per se, but it was just something about it and I thought well you know, this might be a nice thing to do, just a little different concept of it you know. Not to stray too far from it.

MR: That's great. Well, on behalf of Hamilton College I want to thank you for fitting us into your schedule. It's been such a pleasure.

JW: Well thank you, Monk. And give my regards to all your faculty and students there.

MR: I will.

JW: And thank you, so much, for the interview.

MR: Thanks a lot.